

THE EQUITY EXPRESSION OF THE FREIGHT MODAL SHIFT THESIS

Fewer Loads, Longer Trains

American diesel set a record on 7 September, at \$5.967 a gallon — a jump of 36.8 cents in a single week. The reason is well understood by now: a refining shortage, not a crude shortage. What has changed this month is not the diagnosis but the arithmetic downstream of it. Freight volumes are contracting faster than any seasonal norm, the cost of each remaining mile is rising, and the shippers who pay the bill have started re-routing physical goods off the road and onto the railway. The question is no longer what diesel costs. It is which of these changes survives a return to cheaper fuel.

A reframe worth holding onto

The internal view recorded on this theme treats diesel as the transmission channel running from the war to the inflation print to Fed policy. That framing is intact, but it stops one step early. The shock does not only arrive as a number in the CPI. It arrives as a decision inside a logistics department, about which mode carries a load for the next twelve months. Prices revert. Routings, contracts and ramp relationships revert much more slowly.

Method. Every figure below is external, published and dated, and is attributed to its publisher at the point of use: the EIA weekly diesel survey, Cass Information Systems, the Association of American Railroads, the Surface Transportation Board, the Federal Railroad Administration and company results releases. Several figures are this Guide's own arithmetic on those published inputs and are labelled as calculations where they appear. The internal leg is materially degraded in this edition: the Heyokha Wiki server could not be reached, so no theme page, source-summary page or provider issue was read today. Internal views quoted below are second-hand — recorded in dated prior editions of this Guide — and are labelled as such. They have not been re-verified.

A shipper in Chicago has 5,000 tons to move to Los Angeles, two thousand miles away. There are two ways to do it. Two hundred tractor-trailers will burn about 10,400 gallons of diesel between them. One hundred-car intermodal train will burn about 1,850 gallons. That ratio has been roughly constant for decades; it is a fact about steel wheels on steel rail, not about the freight cycle. In February, with diesel near \$3.76, the fuel bill on that move was about \$39,000 by road against \$7,000 by rail — a gap of roughly \$32,000, which is real money but not obviously worth the extra day or two in transit, the drayage at both ends, and the loss of door-to-door control. At this week's \$5.967, the same two options cost about \$62,000 and \$11,000. The gap is now roughly \$51,000. Nothing about the railway improved. The price of the thing the railway was always quietly saving went up by three-fifths, and a decision that used to be finely balanced stopped being finely balanced.

THE STORY IN 60 SECONDS

\$5.967

US national average on-highway diesel, week of 7 September 2026 — a record, and up 36.8 cents on the week.

EIA Weekly On-Highway Diesel Survey, 7 September 2026

−9.3%

Cass Freight Index shipments, August 2026 against a year earlier. The normal seasonal path would have been about −3%.

Cass Information Systems, August 2026 report

+3.8%

US intermodal volume, first 30 weeks of 2026 against 2025, to more than 8.4m units — growth inside a shrinking freight market.

Association of American Railroads, 2026 weekly data

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

A cost shock that lands on the shipper, not the carrier

The first thing to understand about a diesel spike is that trucking companies do not, for the most part, pay for it. Almost every contract freight rate in North America is quoted as a linehaul rate plus a fuel surcharge, and the surcharge is indexed to the published EIA diesel price and reset weekly. When diesel rises, the surcharge rises. DAT Freight & Analytics recorded the average dry-van fuel surcharge moving from 41 cents a mile in February 2026 to 61 cents in March — a rise of roughly half in a single month. The mechanism worked as designed. The carrier's margin was broadly protected; the shipper's invoice was not.

That is why the damage from this shock shows up first in volumes rather than in carrier profitability. Cass Information Systems reported its shipments component down 9.3% year on year in August 2026, against a normal seasonal comparison nearer -3%, while the expenditures component had risen 9.1% year on year in July. Fewer loads, each one costing appreciably more. This is not the signature of a freight recession caused by weak end demand alone, and it is not the signature of a fuel shock absorbed quietly by intermediaries. It is the signature of a cost being pushed all the way through to the party who can respond to it by changing behaviour.

The behaviour that changes is mode choice. Class I railroads move a ton of freight close to 500 miles on a gallon of diesel; a Class 8 truck manages roughly 150 ton-miles per gallon, and CSX reported a system-wide figure of about 535 ton-miles per gallon for 2025. A Federal Railroad Administration audit of the BNSF Chicago–Los Angeles corridor put the comparison in physical terms: a 100-car intermodal train burning 1,850 gallons to move 5,000 tons two thousand miles, against 10,400 gallons for the two hundred tractor-trailers that would carry the same load. Rail's advantage is not marginal. It is a factor of between three and six, depending on corridor and measure.

Where that advantage gets exercised is visible in the data. Through the first thirty weeks of 2026, US intermodal volume rose 3.8% year on year to more than 8.4 million units. J.B. Hunt, the largest domestic intermodal marketing company, moved 578,072 intermodal loads in the second quarter of 2026 — a 10% increase and a quarterly record — with Eastern network loads up 16% and transcontinental up 5%. Industry reporting places the strongest demand growth in the 550-to-1,500-mile band, which is precisely the contested zone where truck and rail genuinely compete on price rather than on capability.

THE ESSENTIAL DISTINCTION

A fuel surcharge does not shield a carrier from the price of diesel. It shields the carrier's margin and hands the bill to the shipper — who then re-prices the mode. *The diesel shock is not primarily a cost problem for trucking. It is a demand problem.*

MECHANISM

How one container moves from road to rail

1. The quote arrives

A shipper prices a 2,000-mile load. The truckload quote carries a linehaul rate plus a fuel surcharge indexed to the EIA weekly diesel price. That surcharge line moved from about 41 cents a mile in February 2026 to 61 cents in March.

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2. The bill passes through

The surcharge is a pass-through, reset weekly. The carrier's margin is largely defended; the shipper absorbs the diesel move in full. Nothing in the contract insulates the party actually paying.

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3. The mode is re-priced

Intermodal burns roughly one-sixth the fuel for the same ton-miles, so its own surcharge line is structurally smaller. The transit penalty — a day or two, plus drayage at each end — has not changed. Only the fuel gap has.

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4. The load stays put

The switch is made on an annual contract, through a specific ramp, with containers and drayage repositioned to serve it. Rebuilding that takes months. The routing therefore outlives the diesel print that prompted it.

Sources: fuel surcharge levels — DAT Freight & Analytics, February and March 2026. Fuel-consumption ratio — Federal Railroad Administration corridor audit of BNSF Chicago–Los Angeles, and Association of American Railroads ton-miles-per-gallon data. Step 4 describes contracting practice as reported by industry participants; it is the most contestable link in this chain and the bear case below attacks it directly.

\$112,500

Annual diesel bill for one truck running 125,000 miles at 6.5 mpg — 19,231 gallons — at current prices, against \$72,308 at February's price. The same truck, the same miles, \$40,000 more fuel.

5.6×

Fuel burned by road against rail for an identical 5,000-ton, 2,000-mile move: 10,400 gallons versus 1,850. This ratio is physical and did not change in 2026. What changed is what a gallon costs.

+58%

Year-on-year growth in J.B. Hunt's intermodal operating income in the second quarter of 2026, to \$150.9m, on segment revenue of \$1.75bn, up 22%.

Sources: truck fuel-bill arithmetic as reported September 2026 (125,000 miles at 6.5 mpg; February and current national diesel prices). Fuel ratio — Federal Railroad Administration corridor audit; the 5.6× figure is this Guide's calculation of 10,400 ÷ 1,850. J.B. Hunt figures — company second-quarter 2026 results, released 22 July 2026.

THE CENTRAL COMPARISON

What the fuel gap on one move is now worth

Road, at \$5.967 (7 Sep 2026)		\$62,057
Road, at February's \$3.76		\$39,104
Rail, at \$5.967 (7 Sep 2026)		\$11,039
Rail, at February's \$3.76		\$6,956

Diesel cost of moving 5,000 tons from Chicago to Los Angeles by each mode. Gallon counts from the Federal Railroad Administration corridor audit (10,400 by road, 1,850 by rail). Prices: \$5.967 per gallon, EIA weekly survey, 7 September 2026; \$3.76 per gallon derived by this Guide from the reported February annual fuel bill of \$72,308 for 19,231 gallons. The multiplications are this Guide's own. Bars are illustrative of one modelled corridor move and cover fuel only — not labour, equipment, drayage, transit time or service reliability, all of which favour road. The rail–road fuel gap on this move widens from about \$32,100 to about \$51,000, a rise of roughly three-fifths.

A USEFUL MENTAL MODEL

Treat mode choice as a lease, not a trade. Freight does not move to rail for a week; it moves on a contract, through a ramp, with equipment repositioned to serve it. *That is why the shift lags the diesel price going up — and why it will lag again coming down.*

What has actually changed

WHAT HAS CHANGED	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN THE DATA	WHY IT CUTS BOTH WAYS
The pie is shrinking	Cass shipments -9.3% year on year in August 2026 against a -3% seasonal norm; the index has been deteriorating year on year for many months.	Rail's volume growth is share gain inside a contracting market. That is a more durable kind of growth than a demand upturn — and a much smaller one.
Rail is taking the contested band	Intermodal +3.8% year on year through week 30; J.B. Hunt intermodal loads +10% to a record 578,072 in Q2, Eastern network +16%.	The 550-to-1,500-mile band is where rail competes on price. It is also where it is most easily lost again on service.
Carriers are defended, shippers are not	Dry-van fuel surcharge 41c to 61c a mile between February and March 2026; expenditures component +9.1% year on year in July.	Pass-through protects trucking margins but guarantees the volume response. The carrier survives the quarter and loses the contract.
Rail service is the binding constraint	Late-August 2026: BNSF system speed 24.8 mph and terminal dwell 22.4 hours; CSX 23.0 mph and 21.95 hours. On-time train arrivals have been reported in the mid-70% range.	Service is what caused the last reverse mode shift. Winning volume the network cannot fluidly absorb is how railways give it back.

BOTH SIDES

Bull and bear, stated fairly

The case for the shift persisting

- **The advantage is physical, not cyclical.** Close to 500 ton-miles per gallon by rail against roughly 150 by truck is a property of rolling resistance. No amount of fleet renewal closes a gap of that size.
- **The gap is now large enough to overcome inertia.** On one modelled 5,000-ton transcontinental move, the fuel differential widens from about \$32,100 to about \$51,000 between February and this week. Shippers move for less than that.
- **The volume is already showing up.** Intermodal +3.8% through week 30 and a record 578,072 loads at J.B. Hunt in the second quarter, with operating income up 58% — this is booked business, not a forecast.
- **Contracts create hysteresis.** Annual pricing, ramp selection and repositioned containers mean the routing decision is not re-taken weekly. The shift should outlast the price that caused it by quarters, not days.
- **The supply shortage is multi-sourced.** Damaged Gulf refining, Russia's diesel export ban and a decade of net refinery closures are independent causes. Diesel tightness does not need any single one of them to persist.

The case against

- **The cause is a margin, and margins mean-revert.** The diesel crack passed \$100 a barrel for the first time in August 2026 and set records in September. That is a dislocation, not a plateau. Russia's export ban runs only to 30 September 2026.
- **Rail is winning share of a market falling 9.3%.** Intermodal's +3.8% against Cass shipments at -9.3% means absolute freight activity is contracting sharply. Share of less is not the same as more.
- **Service is not ready for the volume.** Terminal dwell above 21 hours at both BNSF and CSX in late August, on-time arrivals in the mid-70% range, and reported congestion at inland ramps. Poor service is what sent this freight back to the road last time.
- **The internal mode shift runs the other way too.** Cass attributes part of August's decline to freight moving from less-than-truckload to truckload. Shippers are consolidating into bigger road shipments, not only onto trains.
- **Policy can end the fuel gap.** India raised its diesel export levy from Rs 15.5 to Rs 25.5 a litre on 3 August 2026 to keep barrels at home. Governments intervening in fuel markets is the fastest route to a lower pump price and a reversed decision.

The internal and external accounts diverge on the question of who eventually pays. The internal view recorded on this theme — from 13D Research and from CLSA's *Greed & Fear*, as captured in this Guide's editions of 7 and 27 August 2026 — treats diesel tightness as a durable rent accruing to scarce refining capacity, and expresses the shock as "energy first, gold second". The external freight data suggests the payer is already buckling: Cass shipments at -9.3% year on year in August, against a seasonal norm of -3%, is what demand destruction looks like in its early stages, and demand

destruction is the mechanism by which that rent eventually ends. Both can be true for a while. They cannot both be true for long, and this edition cannot adjudicate between them — not least because, as recorded in the August editions, the relevant Wiki pages carried no internal bear case at all, and the Oil & Gas page's Contradictions section was empty. The conflict is left open.

WATCHLIST

What to watch from here

SIGNAL	PLAIN-ENGLISH READING	WHY IT MATTERS
EIA weekly diesel survey, Tuesdays	The pump price that every fuel surcharge in the country is indexed to.	It is the single input driving the mode-choice arithmetic. A sustained fall back toward \$4 closes most of the gap the whole thesis rests on.
Russia's diesel export ban, expiring 30 September 2026	Whether the largest non-Gulf block of missing supply — roughly a tenth of world diesel before the strikes — returns to the market.	This is the fastest available route to lower diesel. Russian refinery runs fell to 3.6m b/d in July, the lowest since May 2002, so the ban may be a symptom rather than a choice.
Freight volume prints — Cass monthly, AAR weekly	Cass shipments against expenditures, and whether intermodal's share gain is still accumulating week by week or has stalled near +4%.	Together they separate a cost shock from a demand collapse. Shipments stabilising while expenditures stay high would mean the pass-through is being absorbed rather than refused; intermodal flattening while diesel sits at records would mean the constraint is rail capacity, not shipper willingness.
STB weekly service metrics — speed and terminal dwell	Whether the railways can carry the freight they have just won without degrading.	Service failure is the historical trigger for reverse mode shift. Dwell was above 21 hours at both BNSF and CSX in late August.
UP–NS merger docket, comments due 18 November 2026	The volume and seriousness of shipper and rival protests against the \$85bn combination.	It sets the terms on which the industry answers the transit penalty. The STB's projected schedule runs through at least 28 May 2027, with a decision due within 90 days of the record closing.
FOMC, 15–16 September 2026	Whether the Committee raises into an energy shock, with market-implied odds of a 25bp increase reported near 59–60%.	Freight is a cyclical, capital-intensive, rate-sensitive industry. A hike tightens the end demand that the whole volume debate is about.

EXPRESSIONS

Three postures, not one answer

Own the network The Class I railways are the direct claim on the share shift, and the fuel advantage accrues to them structurally rather than cyclically. The cost: volumes that are share gains inside a market down 9.3%, service metrics that are the thesis's own weakest link, and in two cases a merger review that will not conclude before 2027.	Own the conversion layer The intermodal marketing companies sit closest to the load actually switching mode and are asset-light. The cost: a margin sandwiched between rail purchased-transportation costs and shippers who are moving precisely because they have become price-sensitive — the least defensible position in a chain if the fuel gap narrows.	Own the cause instead The refining step captures the shortage at its origin, and has been the dominant expression of it all year. The cost: it is now a crowded, doubled group priced on peak-cycle margins, it gives up the durability argument entirely, and it is the position most exposed to Russian barrels returning on 30 September.
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The companies named below are illustrative of how this theme is expressed in listed equities. They are NOT recommendations, and no view is offered on the merits of any security. Figures are the issuers' or the named publishers' own, as at the dates stated.

JBHT

J.B. Hunt Transport Services

578,072 loads
Q2 2026, 22 Jul

The cleanest read on the mode shift itself. Second-quarter intermodal volume of 578,072 loads was a 10% increase and a quarterly record, with the Eastern network up 16% and transcontinental up 5%. Segment revenue rose 22% to \$1.75bn on an 11% increase in gross revenue per load, and segment operating income rose 58% to \$150.9m. Group revenue was \$3,495.3m with net income of \$181.03m and diluted EPS of \$1.91 against \$1.31. Brokerage turned profitable for the first time in fourteen quarters.

WATCH NEXT

Whether gross revenue per load can keep rising once shippers have finished switching for price reasons.

UNP

Union Pacific

\$85bn merger
comments 18 Nov

The western network, and one half of the proposed coast-to-coast combination. The STB rejected the original application as incomplete on 16 January 2026, accepted a revised filing on 28 May and held it in abeyance pending supplemental information, then restarted the review with protests and requests for conditions due 18 November 2026. Its own intermodal volume declined in the first quarter of 2026 on Oliver Wyman's review, which sits awkwardly beside the industry-level share gain and is worth holding in mind.

WATCH NEXT

The character of the 18 November filings — shipper protests are the variable that has historically decided rail mergers.

NSC

Norfolk Southern

Review restarted
schedule to May 2027

The eastern counterparty. The joint application was filed on 19 December 2025; the board's projected timeline now runs through at least 28 May 2027, with a final decision due within 90 days of the record closing and responses to protests due 16 February 2027. Norfolk Southern's intermodal volume also declined in the first quarter of 2026. The merger case and the modal-shift case are separate arguments that happen to point at the same asset, and conflating them is the error to avoid here.

WATCH NEXT

Whether eastern intermodal volume turns positive independently of the merger, as J.B. Hunt's Eastern network data implies it could.

CSX

CSX Corporation

23.0 mph / 21.95 hrs
late Aug 2026

The eastern network not involved in the merger, and on the available evidence the operational comparator. CSX grew intermodal volume in the first quarter of 2026 and reduced dwell, and reported a system-wide fuel efficiency figure of roughly 535 ton-miles per gallon for 2025 — the number the entire modal argument rests on. Late-August service metrics were a system speed of 23.0 mph and terminal dwell of 21.95 hours, against BNSF's 24.8 mph and 22.4 hours.

WATCH NEXT

Whether dwell holds near 22 hours as volume arrives, or deteriorates and triggers the reverse shift.

ODFL

Old Dominion Freight Line

2026 EPS +5.4%e
company guidance

The less-than-truckload comparator, and the awkward fact in the middle of this thesis. Cass attributes part of August's 9.3% shipment decline to freight shifting out of LTL and into truckload — consolidation into larger road shipments rather than onto trains. Old Dominion expects 2026 earnings per share about 5.4% above 2025 actuals, which is a modest number in a year of extraordinary freight dislocation, and a reminder that a fuel shock does not lift every transport sub-sector.

WATCH NEXT

Whether the LTL-to-truckload shift continues, since it competes with the road-to-rail shift for the same freight.

KNX

Knight-Swift Transportation

5–7% margin drag
industry, Sep 2026

Illustrative of the truckload side paying the bill. The figures here are industry-level, not company-specific: diesel futures above \$5 a gallon for the first time since 2022, reported gross-margin compression of 5 to 7% for long-haul carriers, spot rates below the summer peak with the SONAR National Truckload Index near \$3.35 a mile, and tender rejections flattening around the mid-13% range against 10–11% at the start of the year. Uber Freight projects spot rates 20–25% above year-ago levels through the rest of 2026.

WATCH NEXT

Tender rejections: a fall back toward 10% would signal capacity is not exiting and pricing power is not arriving.

The bottom line

What was repriced this year was not the railway and not the truck. It was a gallon of diesel — and with it, the value of a fuel-efficiency advantage that steel wheels have always had and that nobody had much reason to pay for while fuel was cheap. On one modelled transcontinental move the rail–road fuel gap widened from roughly \$32,100 to roughly \$51,000 between February and this week. Shippers responded the way the arithmetic suggests: intermodal volume is up 3.8% through week 30 and J.B. Hunt set a quarterly intermodal record, with segment operating income up 58%.

The evidence is genuinely mixed, and two facts sit uncomfortably together. Rail is gaining share of a freight market whose shipment count fell 9.3% year on year in August, and the railways' own service metrics — dwell above 21 hours, on-time arrivals in the mid-70s — are the historical trigger for freight going back to the road. The reasonable inference is narrower than the headline: the modal shift is real and is likely to outlast the diesel price that caused it, because contracts and ramp relationships do not reset weekly, but it is a share story inside a contracting market rather than a growth story, and it is hostage to service quality. The next test is specific and close: whether Russia's diesel export ban lapses on 30 September, and whether the pump price follows it down.

Editorial note. This is educational commentary prepared for internal use. It is not investment advice, not a recommendation, and not a solicitation to buy or sell any security. Companies named above are illustrative of how a theme is expressed in listed markets; no view is offered on the merits of any of them. All external figures are attributed and dated, and are point-in-time: prices, spreads, service metrics and rate probabilities move continuously and several figures here will be stale within days. Several figures are this Guide's own arithmetic on published inputs and are labelled as calculations. Internal Wiki material is the opinion of the named research providers, is labelled as a view rather than a forecast, and in this edition is second-hand and unverified for the reasons set out below. Where internal and external accounts conflict, the conflict is stated rather than resolved. Readers should form their own view.

Sources and update notes

(a) Internal. No Heyokha Wiki page, theme page, source-summary page or provider issue was read for this edition. The Heyokha Wiki MCP server was not present in this session: *list_sources*, *list_pages*, *get_page*, *get_relations* and *search_wiki* were all unavailable, so the entity-scoring and theme-ranking procedure that normally chooses the topic could not be run, and no *last_reviewed* or page-creation date could be read today. Internal material is therefore cited entirely second-hand, from the sourcing sections of dated prior editions of this Guide held in the archive folder. Those editions record: the **Oil & Gas** theme page (created 23 June 2026, last reviewed 20 July 2026, 10,376 words) including its section "July 2026: SPR depletion, crack spreads, and diesel tightness", relying on 13D Research WILTW of 16 July 2026 for the crack-spread and diesel-tightness material and *Greed & Fear* (CLSA, Chris Wood) of 16 July 2026 for the diesel transmission mechanism; and the **Iran War** theme page (created 23 June 2026, last reviewed 21 August 2026, 8,466 words), relying on *Greed & Fear* "40 trillion and counting" of 20 August 2026 for the diesel-crack observation and the "energy first, gold second" portfolio statement, and on A. Gary Shilling's *Insight* of 1 July and 1 August 2026 for the inflation-persistence channel to Fed policy. Those attributions are reproduced as recorded on 7 and 27 August 2026 and have not been re-verified against the Wiki today.

(b) Limitation on the internal view. Two limitations apply, and the second is the more serious. First, provider concentration: as recorded in the 7 August edition, roughly fifty of the fifty-four sources on the Oil & Gas page are 13D Research issues, with a handful of *Greed & Fear* notes and a single Solid Ground reference reaching it only through backlinks — no White Box, Marc Faber or HS Dent material feeds the theme at all — and that page's Contradictions section was empty. The Iran War page carried 25 references, again predominantly 13D, and the 27 August edition noted that no source on it argued for de-escalation. Second, and specific to today: because the Wiki could not be reached, this edition has no live internal view whatsoever. There is no house framing of freight or modal substitution, no record of what the firm has previously been wrong about here, and no long-horizon provider counterweight. The topic name "Freight Modal Shift", the reframe in the page-one sidebar, the headline and the entire analytical frame are the editor's construction, not a researched house position, and "Freight Modal Shift" is not a verified Wiki theme title. This should be read as a briefing assembled from public sources.

(c) External sources. 1. US national average on-highway diesel \$5.967 a gallon for the week of 7 September 2026, up 36.8 cents on the week — EIA Weekly On-Highway Diesel Survey, as reported by Forbes, 9 September 2026. AAA national average \$5.85 on 4 September 2026, passing the previous record of \$5.816 set 19 June 2022; a national retail figure of \$5.98 was subsequently reported. 2. Cass Freight Index shipments component −9.3% year on year in August 2026 against a normal seasonal comparison of about −3%, with part of the decline attributed to a continuing shift from less-than-truckload to truckload; expenditures component +9.1% year on year in July 2026 — Cass Information Systems, August 2026 report. 3. US intermodal volume +3.8% year on year through the first 30 weeks of 2026, to more than 8.4m units — Association of American Railroads, 2026 weekly data. 4. Average dry-van fuel surcharge 41 cents a mile in February 2026 rising to 61 cents in March 2026 — DAT Freight & Analytics. 5. Class I railroads move one ton of freight nearly 500 miles per

gallon against roughly 150 ton-miles per gallon for the average Class 8 truck — Association of American Railroads; CSX system-wide train efficiency approximately 535 ton-miles per gallon for 2025 — CSX. 6. A 100-car intermodal train consuming 1,850 gallons to move 5,000 tons 2,000 miles, against 10,400 gallons for 200 tractor-trailers on the same move — Federal Railroad Administration operational audit of the BNSF Chicago–Los Angeles corridor, 2023. 7. J.B. Hunt second-quarter 2026 results, released 22 July 2026 — intermodal volume 578,072 loads, +10% and a quarterly record; transcontinental +5%, Eastern +16%; JBI segment revenue \$1.75bn, +22%, on an 11% rise in gross revenue per load; segment operating income \$150.9m, +58%; group revenue \$3,495.30m; net income \$181.03m; diluted EPS from continuing operations \$1.91 against \$1.31; group operating income \$259.5m, +32%; \$210.06m of share repurchases completed; brokerage profitable for the first time in fourteen quarters; shares +65% over the preceding year. 8. Strongest intermodal demand growth in the 550-to-1,500-mile band; national average diesel around \$5.65 a gallon and the SONAR National Truckload Index near \$3.35 a mile in early September 2026; tender rejections flattening around the mid-13% range against 10–11% at the start of 2026; truckload spot rates a record \$3.83 a mile in early June 2026; Uber Freight projecting spot rates 20–25% above year-ago levels for the remainder of 2026 — freight-market reporting, 2026. 9. Truck fuel arithmetic: 125,000 miles a year at 6.5 mpg equals 19,231 gallons; annual fuel bill \$72,308 at February's price against \$112,500 currently; diesel futures above \$5 a gallon for the first time since 2022; reported gross-margin compression of 5 to 7% for long-haul carriers; trucks carry roughly 70% of US freight — trucking-industry reporting, September 2026. 10. Class I service metrics for late August 2026: BNSF system speed 24.8 mph and terminal dwell 22.4 hours; CSX system speed 23.0 mph and terminal dwell 21.95 hours — Surface Transportation Board weekly data. First-quarter 2026 intermodal volume up at CSX, BNSF, CN and FEX and down at NS, UP and CPKC, with dwell falling at all railroads except CN — Oliver Wyman, North American Class I Freight Rail Performance, Q1 2026. On-time arrival of dispatched trains reported in the mid-70% range, with congestion at seaport and inland intermodal ramps. 11. Union Pacific–Norfolk Southern: joint application filed 19 December 2025; not accepted as complete on 16 January 2026; revised application filed 30 April 2026 and accepted for consideration on 28 May 2026, then held in abeyance pending supplemental information; review restarted with comments, protests and requests for conditions due 18 November 2026, responses due 16 February 2027, projected schedule running through at least 28 May 2027 and a final decision due within 90 days of the close of the record; transaction value \$85bn — Surface Transportation Board releases and associated reporting, 2026. 12. Diesel-market backdrop: US Gulf Coast diesel crack against WTI passed \$100 a barrel on 17 August 2026 for the first time, with a record above \$106 reported on 1 September 2026; US distillate inventories just above 103m barrels for the week ended 21 August 2026, a fourth consecutive weekly fall and the lowest August level since 1951, and 106.3m barrels as at 4 September 2026, with the EIA forecasting a fall below 100m barrels in September — RBN Energy, 27 August 2026; Bloomberg, 1 September 2026; EIA Weekly Petroleum Status Report and Short-Term Energy Outlook. Russian refining volumes 3.6m b/d in July 2026, the lowest since May 2002, with Russia's diesel export ban extended to 30 September 2026 and Russia accounting for roughly 10% of global diesel supply before the strikes — Reuters and associated reporting, 29 August 2026. 13. India raised the Special Additional Excise Duty on diesel exports from Rs 15.5 to Rs 25.5 a litre effective 3 August 2026 — Indian government notification and associated reporting. 14. WTI above \$100 a barrel on 10 September 2026 with Brent above \$106, and WTI \$102.59 on 11 September 2026, up roughly 23% over the preceding month; a hotter-than-expected August PPI print; FOMC meeting 15–16 September 2026 with an updated dot plot and market-implied odds of a 25bp increase reported near 59–60% — market reporting, 8–11 September 2026.

(d) Editorial choices made in this automated run. Three choices are worth recording. First, on topic selection: the Wiki was unreachable, so the hot-first entity-scoring procedure could not run and the topic was chosen from the live tape instead. The hot signal was unambiguous — record retail diesel on 4 and 7 September, WTI through \$100 on 10 September, and record August rail volumes — and the obvious topic was refining margins. That topic was rejected. The archive's 27 August 2026 edition is filed under the topic "Iran War" but is titled "The Crack, Not The Barrel" and is substantively a refining-margin edition; running it again fifteen days later would have repeated an edition the reader has already had, even though a filename parse would not catch it. The cooldown check was therefore applied to substance as well as to filename, and the chosen topic is the uncovered other side of the same shock: who pays the diesel bill, and what they do about it. Second, on the cooldown check itself: this was fully verifiable. The archive folder was directly readable — the remote-devices bridge was also absent from this session, but proved unnecessary — and 43 files were parsed, giving 26 topics used in the 30 days to 11 September 2026, among them AI Capex, Copper, Gold, Silver Miners, Defense, Optical Interconnect, China Biotech, Stagflation, Term Premium and Power Affordability. Two filename conventions coexist in the folder, one hyphenated and one with the double-space format, and both were parsed. Nothing resembling freight, trucking, rail or modal substitution appears anywhere in the archive. Third, on tool failures: the Heyokha Wiki MCP server and the remote-devices bridge were both absent, and an attempt to reach the Wiki through the available Notion connector failed — it returned an unrelated engineering page, and semantic search on that connector is gated behind a higher plan tier. The bear case in this edition was built almost entirely from external reporting and from tensions inside the published data — principally the combination of rising intermodal volume with a 9.3% fall in total shipments, and service metrics that undercut the durability argument — because no internal bear case was available to draw on.